

D265

Critical Thinking: Reason and Evidence

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

At a city council meeting that ran three hours, a resident says: "The new bike lane cut traffic injuries on Oak Street by half. Injuries cost the city money. Therefore, the city should add bike lanes on Main Street." The resident has lived in the city for 30 years. What is the conclusion of the argument?

- A. The city should add bike lanes on Main Street.
- B. The resident's 30 years make the argument reliable.
- C. Injuries cost the city money.
- D. The bike lane cut injuries on Oak Street by half.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A logic student at a school with a strong debate team evaluates this argument: "All birds can fly. Penguins are birds. So penguins can fly." Which describes it?

- A. Valid but unsound.
- B. Strong but not cogent.
- C. Sound, because the form is correct.
- D. Invalid, because the conclusion is false.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

An argument has true premises and a true conclusion. Must it be valid?

- A. Yes, and it is also sound.
- B. Only if it is an inductive argument.
- C. No; true statements can be linked by a form that does not guarantee the conclusion.
- D. Yes; true premises and a true conclusion make an argument valid.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A product manager at a phone maker with a new flagship model asks five coworkers in her office whether they like the new design. All five say yes, so she reports that customers love it. The design team worked on the phone for two years. What is the main weakness in her reasoning?

- A. An ad hominem attack.
- B. A hasty generalization from a small, unrepresentative sample.
- C. Two years is too short to design a phone.
- D. None; 100% agreement proves the claim.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

During a school board debate held in a packed gym, one member proposes a modest cut to the sports budget to fund tutoring. Another member replies, "She wants to get rid of all sports and make our kids sit inside all day." Which fallacy is this?

- A. Appeal to popularity, since the gym was packed.
- B. Straw man.
- C. Ad hominem.
- D. Slippery slope.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which reply is an ad hominem rather than a straw man?

- A. "You can't trust his budget plan; he was fired from his last job."
- B. "Either we cut tutoring or we cut sports; there's no other way."
- C. "If we cut sports, next it will be music, then art."
- D. "He wants to cut every program in the district."

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A news site with 2 million readers reports that cities with more coffee shops have higher average incomes and concludes that opening coffee shops raises incomes. The article includes a colorful map. What is the main flaw?

- A. No flaw; a strong correlation always proves cause.
- B. Correlation does not show causation; wealth may attract coffee shops, or a third factor may drive both.
- C. The map is misleading.
- D. The sample of cities is too small.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A study finds that students who eat breakfast earn higher grades. Which finding would most weaken the claim that breakfast causes higher grades?

- A. A randomized trial found that assigning breakfast raised grades.
- B. Some breakfast eaters still get low grades.
- C. Breakfast eaters also tend to come from households with more income and study support.
- D. Nutritionists recommend eating breakfast.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A blog post claims a new supplement cures insomnia. The author is a well-known actor who says he sleeps better, and the website sells the supplement. The post has 50,000 likes. How credible is the claim?

- A. High, because the post is popular.
- B. High, because the author is famous.
- C. Low, because every blog post is false.
- D. Low; the author lacks relevant expertise, profits from sales, and offers only his own story.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which source would be most credible on whether a new medication lowers blood pressure?

- A.** The manufacturer's press release.
- B.** A celebrity's video testimonial.
- C.** A large online poll of users.
- D.** A peer-reviewed randomized controlled trial by independent researchers.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A buyer for a used-car dealership with 120 cars on its lot sees a \$30,000 sticker price on a truck worth about \$22,000. After negotiating, she feels she got a great deal at \$26,000. The truck is painted a popular color. Which bias shaped her judgment?

- A.** Confirmation bias.
- B.** Sunk-cost fallacy.
- C.** Anchoring.
- D.** The bandwagon effect from the popular color.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

At a startup with 35 employees, a manager tells the team, “Either we work every weekend this quarter, or the company will fail.” The company just moved into a larger office. What is wrong with this reasoning?

- A.** It is an ad hominem.
- B.** It is a slippery slope.
- C.** Nothing; startups always fail without weekend work.
- D.** It is a false dilemma that ignores options such as cutting scope, reprioritizing, or hiring.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer A Concept 1

At a city council meeting ~~that ran three hours~~, a resident says: "The new bike lane cut traffic injuries on Oak Street by half. Injuries cost the city money. Therefore, the city should add bike lanes on Main Street." ~~The resident has lived in the city for 30 years.~~ What is the conclusion of the argument?

Target word: identify the conclusion **Decides:** "Therefore" introduces the claim being argued for.

A	Correct	The claim the other statements support.
B	Camouflage	Residency length is not part of the argument's structure.
C	Confusion set	A premise offered as a reason.
D	Adjacent category	The evidence premise, not the conclusion.

2. Answer A Concept 2

A logic student ~~at a school with a strong debate team~~ evaluates this argument: "All birds can fly. Penguins are birds. So penguins can fly." Which describes it?

Target word: classify the argument **Decides:** Correct form, false first premise.

A	Correct	The conclusion follows from the premises, but "all birds can fly" is false.
B	Adjacent category	Those terms rate inductive arguments; this one is deductive.
C	Dropped element	Soundness also requires true premises.
D	Confusion set	Validity is about form, not the truth of the conclusion.

3. Answer C Concept 2 · transfer

An argument has true premises and a true conclusion. Must it be valid?

Target word: reverse: does truth guarantee validity **Decides:** Validity depends on whether the conclusion follows.

A	Absolute language	Soundness requires validity, which is not guaranteed.
B	Adjacent category	Validity is a deductive concept.
C	Correct	Validity is a property of the reasoning, not the truth of its parts.
D	Inverted operation	Reverses the relationship between truth and validity.

4. Answer B Concept 3

A product manager at a phone maker ~~with a new flagship model~~ asks five coworkers in her office whether they like the new design. All five say yes, so she reports that customers love it. ~~The design team worked on the phone for two years.~~ What is the main weakness in her reasoning?

Target word: main weakness **Decides:** Five coworkers stand in for all customers.

A	Confusion set	No one's character is attacked.
B	Correct	Five coworkers are neither many nor typical customers.
C	Camouflage	Design time does not affect the survey's reasoning.
D	Absolute language	Unanimity in a biased sample proves little.

5. Answer B Concept 4

During a school board debate ~~held in a packed gym~~, one member proposes a modest cut to the sports budget to fund tutoring. Another member replies, "She wants to get rid of all sports and make our kids sit inside all day." Which fallacy is this?

Target word: name the fallacy **Decides:** The reply distorts the proposal.

A	Camouflage	Crowd size is setting, not the reasoning used.
B	Correct	A modest cut is recast as eliminating all sports, then attacked.
C	Confusion set	The reply misstates her position rather than attacking her character.
D	Adjacent category	Slippery slope predicts a chain of consequences; this rewrites the proposal itself.

6. Answer A Concept 4 • transfer

Which reply is an ad hominem rather than a straw man?

Target word: reverse: find the ad hominem **Decides:** Attacks the person, not the claim.

A	Correct	Targets the person's history instead of the plan.
B	Confusion set	False dilemma.
C	Adjacent category	Slippery slope.
D	Inverted operation	Distorts the position: straw man.

7. Answer B Concept 5

A news site ~~with 2 million readers~~ reports that cities with more coffee shops have higher average incomes and concludes that opening coffee shops raises incomes. ~~The article includes a colorful map.~~ What is the main flaw?

Target word: main flaw **Decides:** A correlation is presented as a cause.

A	Absolute language	Correlation alone never establishes cause.
B	Correct	Reverse causation and confounders are not ruled out.
C	Camouflage	The map's design does not decide the logic.
D	Adjacent category	Sample size is not the problem described.

8. Answer C Concept 5 • transfer

A study finds that students who eat breakfast earn higher grades. Which finding would most weaken the claim that breakfast causes higher grades?

Target word: reverse: find the weakener **Decides:** A third factor that could explain both.

A	Inverted operation	Strengthens the causal claim.
B	Absolute language	One exception does not undo a trend.
C	Correct	A confounder could produce both breakfast and grades.
D	Adjacent category	An appeal to authority that does not address cause.

9. Answer D Concept 6

A blog post claims a new supplement cures insomnia. The author is a well-known actor who says he sleeps better, and the website sells the supplement. ~~The post has 50,000 likes.~~ How credible is the claim?

Target word: credibility **Decides:** No relevant expertise and a financial conflict of interest.

A	Camouflage	Likes are not evidence.
B	Confusion set	Fame is not expertise in sleep medicine.
C	Absolute language	Right verdict, wrong reason; blogs vary in credibility.
D	Correct	Expertise, independence, and evidence are all missing.

10. Answer D Concept 6 • transfer

Which source would be most credible on whether a new medication lowers blood pressure?

Target word: reverse: find the credible source **Decides:** Independent, expert, strong evidence.

A	Confusion set	Has data but a direct financial interest.
B	Inverted operation	No expertise and only one person's story.
C	Adjacent category	Self-selected opinions, not controlled evidence.
D	Correct	Expert review, strong design, and no sales motive.

11. Answer C Concept 7

A buyer for a used-car dealership ~~with 120 cars on its lot~~ sees a \$30,000 sticker price on a truck worth about \$22,000. After negotiating, she feels she got a great deal at \$26,000. ~~The truck is painted a popular color.~~ Which bias shaped her judgment?

Target word: name the bias **Decides:** The first price set her sense of a good deal.

A	Confusion set	That is seeking evidence for a belief already held.
B	Adjacent category	Sunk cost is sticking with a choice because of past spending.
C	Correct	The \$30,000 sticker made \$26,000 feel cheap, though it is \$4,000 over value.
D	Camouflage	The color did not drive her price judgment.

12. Answer D Concept 8

At a startup ~~with 35 employees~~, a manager tells the team, "Either we work every weekend this quarter, or the company will fail." ~~The company just moved into a larger office.~~ What is wrong with this reasoning?

Target word: name the flaw **Decides:** Only two options are offered.

A	Adjacent category	No one's character is attacked.
B	Confusion set	No chain of escalating steps is claimed.
C	Absolute language	An unsupported universal claim.
D	Correct	Other paths exist between the two extremes.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owled.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	1	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	10	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	4	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	6	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	9	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	6	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Premises and conclusion	The conclusion is the claim being argued for; premises are the reasons offered for it. Words like “therefore” and “so” flag the conclusion.	Picking a strong-sounding premise as the conclusion.	“Therefore,” “so,” “should.”
2	Validity vs. soundness	A valid argument's conclusion must follow if the premises are true; a sound argument is valid and has all true premises.	Calling an argument invalid because a premise or conclusion is false.	A correct form with a false premise.
3	Hasty generalization	Inductive conclusions need samples that are large enough and representative of the group.	Trusting unanimous agreement from a small, convenient sample.	A handful of people close at hand stand in for a whole population.
4	Straw man vs. ad hominem	A straw man distorts the opponent's position and attacks the distortion; ad hominem attacks the person instead of the argument.	Calling any hostile reply ad hominem.	Is the reply about the claim (misstated) or about the person?
5	Correlation vs. causation	Two things moving together does not show one causes the other; a third factor or reverse causation may explain it.	Treating a strong correlation as proof of cause.	“Places with more X have more Y, so X causes Y.”
6	Source credibility	Judge a source by relevant expertise, independence from conflicts of interest, and quality of evidence, not by fame or popularity.	Trusting celebrity, likes, or confidence.	A claim from someone who profits from it or lacks relevant expertise.
7	Anchoring bias	An initial number or impression pulls later judgments toward it, even when it is arbitrary.	Confusing anchoring with confirmation bias.	A first price or estimate that shapes what feels reasonable.
8	False dilemma	A false dilemma presents only two options when others exist.	Confusing it with slippery slope.	“Either ... or ...” with no middle ground.

Course scope (public description): In this course you will learn key critical thinking concepts and how to apply them in the analysis and evaluation of reasons and evidence. The course examines the basic components of an argument, the credibility of evidence sources, the impact of bias, and how to construct an argument that provides good support for a claim. The course consists of an introduction and four major sections. Each section includes learning opportunities through readings, videos, audio, and other relevant resources. Assessment activities with feedback also provide opportunities to check your learning, practice, and show how well you understand course content. Because the course is self-paced, you may move through the material as quickly or as slowly as you need to gain proficiency in the four competencies that will be covered in the final assessment. If you have no prior knowledge or experience, you can expect to spend 30-40 hours on the course content.